

2 Android as a development platform

Applications for Android are developed using a group of tools provided with the Android SDK (software development kit). These tools can be accessed through an Eclipse plugin called Android Development Tools (ADT), or also from the command line. Developing with Eclipse is preferred as it has the ability to directly invoke tools required to develop applications. You can, however, choose any other text editor or an integrated development environment (IDE), and invoke the tools from the command line or use scripts. For the purpose of this Fast Track, we'll be referring to Eclipse IDE only.

Basic steps for developing applications:

1. Install Eclipse along with the ADT plugin.
2. Create Android Virtual Devices (AVD) or connect hardware devices you want to install your apps on.
3. Build your application and run it.
4. Debug your application using the debugging and logging tools available in the Android SDK.
5. Test your application on your hardware or on an emulator.

For references regarding tools to use if you are working on command line, check: <http://developer.android.com/guide/developing/tools/index.html>

2.1 Installing the SDK

This section will describe the basic know-how to prepare your computer for developing Android applications.

2.1.1 Getting your system ready

Check your system requirements:

- Windows XP (32-bit) or higher
- Mac OS X 10.5.8 or later (x86 only)
- Linux (tested on Ubuntu Linux, Lucid Lynx)
- GNU C Library (glibc) 2.7 or later is required
- On Ubuntu, version 8.04 or later is required
- 64-bit distributions must be capable of running 32-bit applications

Install the Java Development Kit (JDK) from <http://java.sun.com/javase/downloads/index.jsp>.

Download Eclipse 3.5 (Galileo) or higher from <http://www.eclipse.org/downloads/>